

An Historical Study of English

Function, form and change

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Transmission II: sound-change

PHONEME AND ALLOPHONE

In Chapter 3, it was observed that linguistic variation arose in two ways: through divergence from a common inherited ancestor, and through contact with other varieties or languages, that is, through the interaction of intra- and extralinguistic phenomena. In the last chapter, the standardisation of written English in particular was placed within its extralinguistic and intralinguistic context. In this chapter, the attention shifts to the transmission of the spoken mode, that is, phonology and phonetics, and it will be observed that dynamic interaction between extra- and intralinguistic processes is similarly of key importance. In short, it is argued here that a given sound-change is the result of a number of factors, both intra- and extralinguistic, acting in combination.

Historical linguists have traditionally focused their attention on soundsystems—that is, phonology—rather than phonetic detail, and there are good reasons for this. If we leave aside the science of phonological reconstruction, the history of sounds, before the widespread use of mechanical and electronic methods of recording language in the twentieth century, has to depend on the study of written language. As was noted in Chapter 2, alphabetic writing-systems, such as that in which English is and has been recorded, are designed to distinguish the smallest meaningfully distinctive units of language, and are thus broadly phonemic in the way in which they map the spoken mode—even though, given spellingtraditions, this mapping may reflect an earlier stage in the language's history.

Linguists have traditionally compiled a language's or variety's phonemic inventory by noting the existence of 'minimal pairs', that is, pairs of words in which a difference of a single sound in an identical phonetic environment indicates a difference of meaning. To distinguish allophones (i.e. varying realisations of phonemes) in orthography is in principle uneconomical and would be communicatively confusing. Efficient written communication therefore depends on a correlation between grapheme and phoneme. As a result, we can expect at least a tendency for allophonic variation not to be reflected in the written mode.

Yet to concentrate on phonological system at the expense of allophonic variation in a history of sounds can be misleading. To take a simple example: the major difference between the consonantal phonology of Middle English and that of Old English is the addition of a distinction between voiced and voiceless fricatives. In the case of /v/, /f/ this is frequently considered to be one of the few examples of French influence on the English phonological system. The addition of minimal pairs derived from French, such as *vine*: *fine*, to the English lexicon meant that [v] and [f], hitherto allophones, became phonemicised. The post-Conquest scribal distinction between (v) and (f) seems to result from this phonemicisation.

To state, therefore, that Old English had no distinction between /v/ and /f/, whereas Middle English did, is entirely fair—in phonemic terms. However, that is not to say that Old English did not distinguish between the sounds [v] and [f]. Almost all students of Old English agree that fricatives were voiced intervocally and voiceless elsewhere during the historical Old English period. In Old English the distribution of [v], [f] was complementary, so that ⟨f⟩ in *fela* ‘many’ signified [f], but ⟨f⟩ in *yfel* ‘evil’ signified [v]. Moreover, some varieties of Old English, notably Southern ones, evidently had a much wider distribution of initial voiced fricatives than others; and some of these voiced sounds subsequently spread beyond their area of origin (cf. Present-Day English *vixen* beside the related male *fox*).¹

It would seem, therefore, that the relationship between phonological system and allophonic variation has to be catered for in the practice of historical linguistics, even if the evidence for variation is uncertain. The relationship is—like all features of linguistic development—iterative: allophonic variation has the potential (although it need not) to lead to phonological change, and phonological system can (although it need not) constrain the range of possible allophonic variation.

PHONEMICISATION

In diachronic study, the relationship between allophone and phoneme can be seen very clearly in the process of phonemicisation. Phonemicisation may be defined as when two allophonic realisations of an original phoneme start to be used in situations where the choice of one or the other changes the meaning of the word; thus minimal pairs arise, such as /p^hu/ ‘put’ beside /p^uu/ ‘putt’ in some varieties of Present-Day English, reflecting a distinction which arose in Southern English in the seventeenth century; or the distinction between Present-Day English *house* (noun), with final /s/, and *house* (verb), with final /z/. The Old English forms for these words were *hūs* and *hūsan* respectively; the distribution of [s] and [z] was allophonic in Old English, in that [z] was used intervocally whereas [s] was used finally. With the loss of the inflection on the verb during the Middle English period, a new minimal pair existed and thus a new phonemic distinction arose, between /s/ and /z/.

As we might expect, the emergence of phonemes has an important impact on the evolution of alphabetic writing-systems; and we are fortunate in that, for much of the history of the English language, the forces of written standardisation did not obscure this process. To demonstrate the interplay between phonemicisation and writing-system an Early Old English example will be examined: the significance of *y*, and its representation in the runic script. The choice of such an early example is required because of later educational developments; as several scholars have pointed out, increasing conventionalisation of spelling since the late Middle Ages has brought about stability and conservatism in orthography, so that changes in phonological structure are no longer generally reflected in the written mode.

The appearance of *y* was for some time one of the major puzzles in the history of Anglo-Saxon orthography. The letter was adopted into the Roman alphabet from Greek *υ*, *Ypsilon*, a variant of *Ϝ* which has given the modern alphabetic *u* and *v*. In Roman practice, it was originally confined to Greek words imitated or reproduced in Latin, and it corresponded phonetically to [y], a front close rounded vowel. There is, further, some evidence in the Latin grammatical tradition that *υ* is also the symbol for a diphthong [ui]. An awareness of this history of the letter is demonstrated by the eleventh-century Anglo-Saxon monastic writer Ælfric, who in his *Grammar* referred to *y* as *se grecisca y*, ‘the Greek *y*’; the symbol is still referred to as *y-grec* in French. It seems likely that the early Anglo-Saxon orthographers were aware of the symbol as a marginal feature of Latin, and simply exploited it. In later Latin, those Greek words with [y] = *y* were reinterpreted as containing Latin [i], and thus *i*, *y* became alternative graphs—as they became in Middle English when, in most dialects, Old English *y* [y(?)] was unrounded. In Middle English times, *y* was used

instead of *i* especially in 'minim environments', that is where *i* appeared in a sequence preceded or followed by the letters *m*, *n* or *u*; in many varieties of medieval handwriting all these letters were written using the same minim-stroke, and there was thus scope for potential confusion which the use of *y* avoided.

In Old English, *y* is used (1) as the reflex in Late West Saxon of Early West Saxon *ie*, and (2) to reflect the outcome of a prehistoric Old English sound-change, the *i*-mutation of earlier *u*. The second of these usages, whose development can be reconstructed by logical means, will be discussed here.

The phonetic processes involved in *i*-mutation may be summarised thus: 'the mode of utterance of an accented vowel [is approximated] to that of an *i* or *i* [i.e. *j*] of the following syllable' (Campbell 1959:72); in other words, to produce [y], an older close rounded *back* vowel [u] took on the *front* quality of the vowel in the following syllable. The [i, j] of the unstressed syllable was generally subsequently lost and does not appear in the written records of Old English, although its sometime presence can be detected, for example by comparison with the early Germanic language in which the mutation does not seem to have taken place, Gothic. The distinctive feature adopted was 'frontness' or palatality.²

The process of *i*-mutation is clearly demonstrated in the development of the Anglo-Saxon runic script, the *futhorc*. *I*-mutation is an innovation in prehistoric Old English, and the earlier West Germanic runic script, the *futhark*, did not have a rune for '*i*-mutated *u*'. The runemasters, therefore, faced by this new phenomenon, devised an ingenious expedient; they took the runes **h** and **i**, usually transliterated as '*u*' and '*i*' respectively, and blended them to produce **h** 'y'. That this represents the operation of *i*-mutation on older *u* is demonstrated by the inscription **PNMIF** 'wylif' (=Present-Day English 'she-wolf') on the Auzon (Franks) Casket (c. 700 AD). Old English *wylf* (fem.) corresponds to the masculine *wulf* (Proto-Germanic **wulfi-*, **wulfa-*); the minimal pair in recorded Old English demonstrates the phonemicisation.³

ALLOPHONIC VARIATION

It will have been observed from the discussion so far that phonological changes in the spoken mode do map onto the written language when the latter is comparatively fluid, even if at some removes and even though the written mode needs careful philological analysis. It will also have been observed that *variation* in the allophonic realisation of phonemes is a necessary prerequisite—that is, it provides the *potential*—for the process of phonemicisation; and this observation correlates with the discussion of the mechanisms of change outlined in Chapter 3 above.

The production of allophonic variants, which may be metaphorically described as the small change of phonological evolution, can be widely observed in Present-Day English, and it is perhaps worth beginning this stage of the discussion by considering the sources and kinds of allophonic variation which can exist. These allophonic variants exist within the wide bounds of each phoneme's *variational space*, the important notion which was introduced in Chapter 3. Variation within the phonological space of an individual can be produced by such mechanical factors as follows:

- 1 *Assimilation phenomena*, whether between segments (e.g. Present-Day English [br^htθ] *breadth*, where the original [d], indicated by the spelling ⟨d⟩, has taken on the voiceless quality of the neighbouring [θ]; cf. the related adjective *broad*) or at a distance (e.g. mutation or 'umlaut', as recorded in Present-Day Southern US English; cf. the difference in the quality of the stressed vowel in such pairs of words as 'jelly' with [ɛ]: 'cellar' with [ɛ̃], 'horrid' with [a+] : 'horror' with [a], recorded by Wells 1982:533–534. The quality of the stressed vowel in such words seems to be determined by the quality of the following unstressed vowel).

- 2 *Loss or addition of segments* (e.g. Present-Day Scots [fak] for fact, or Present-Day Southern US English diphthongisation ('breaking') in words like [lʰəp] *lip*; see Wells 1982:535).
- 3 *Conflation of repeated sequences* (e.g. [ˈvɛtənɹɪ] for *veterinary*).
- 4 *Dissimilation within phonological space*: a good example is found in the dialects of German in modern Switzerland. Samuels (1972:31) notes that certain Swiss dialects possessing the three phonemes /aː/, /æː/ and /ɔː/ use only central allophones of /aː/, whereas those with only the two phonemes /aː/ and /æː/ have a greater allophonic range for /aː/ and typically show a more retracted vowel.
- In Present-Day English, it is noticeable that retraction of /aː/ is found in dialects where fronting of Middle English /a/ has occurred; retraction is not generally found in dialects where fronting of Middle English /a/ has not occurred, and which therefore retain original quantitative distinctions between /a/ and /aː/. A good example of the latter is Jamaican English (see Wells 1982:575).
- 5 *Metatheses*, that is, reversal in the ordering of segments (e.g. Present-Day Southern English [aks], [wɔps] for *ask*, *wasp*), or *metanalyses*, where the boundaries between words are reassigned, such as Present-Day Standard English *an adder* for *older* (and still-dialectal) *nadder* (cf. the Present-Day German cognate *Natter*).
- 6 *Analogical formations introducing variable word-stress*, for instance [ˈkɒntrə.vəsi] for [kənˈtrɒvəsi] *controversy*, on the model of [ˈkɒntrəˈvɜːʃəl] *controversial*.
- 7 Variants may also be produced in conditions of *greater or lesser stress*. Thus a word like *yes* can be realised in speech as [jɛs] or [jə] depending on context. The effects of stress on segments have been experimentally proved: in vowels it has been shown that stress induces more close and fronted tongue-positions, for example stressed [dæʊn] *down*! beside less stressed [daʊn] *down* in Present-Day London English, while in consonants aspirated variants are produced, such as stressed [ghəʊ] *go*! beside less stressed [gəʊ] *go*. Similarly, the realisation of /iː/ in *meat* may vary between (say) [i] and [iː] depending on the degree of stress assigned to the word.
- 8 Finally, phonetic realisations can change over time, as the individual grows. It is an observable physiological fact that a child's realisation of a particular sound differs in acoustic quality from that of an adult (see Lieberman 1984:159).

Then there is contact-induced variation. It can, of course, happen on a microlinguistic scale; every individual's set of phonological realisations differs slightly, given the slight variation in size and/or shape of each human vocal tract, and thus any speaker will encounter a range of slight variation in everyday conversation. Processes of readjustment can follow as a result of monitoring. But this process also occurs on a macrolinguistic scale when one speech-community, through invasion, immigration or social aspiration, comes into contact with another; and it can be very subtle. Thus some Southern English people prototypically realise the (a) in *cat* with [æ], whereas other more Northerly people prototypically realise it as [a]. This kind of contact can introduce new elements into the variational space for an item within a community, and subsequent readjustments can result.

One such readjustment is *hypercorrection* or (perhaps more accurately) *hyperadaptation*, which has already been defined on pages 26–27 above. Faced with messy phonetic variation in their linguistic communities, users 'miss the target' in the way in which they interpret and reflect the phonetic outputs they encounter, in a situation of monitoring; pragmatic and sociolinguistic pressures are frequently present here. Thus an habitual 'h-dropper' may, in certain circumstances, introduce an initial *h-* into all sorts of situations where initial *h-* never existed in the past (e.g. [haʃ] for *h*).

Such mechanical and contact-induced variation contributes to the pool of available variation in any speech-community, itself made up of usages inherited from earlier in the variety's history or borrowed from varieties with which the host variety has come into contact. These inherited and borrowed usages may be described as 'givens'; and it is argued here that the interaction between givens and the kinds of variation described above provides us with a good model of the variational space available at any stage in the history of English.

This range of variation represents the *potential* for linguistic change; the *triggering* (or *actuation*) and *implementation* of the change takes place when a number of linguistic processes interact to produce a systemic development. To demonstrate the workings of this interaction, two examples will be chosen: one is from Present-Day English, to do with the distribution of certain dental and fricative sounds in the Present-Day Liverpudlian accent, Scouse; the other example is the Great Vowel Shift of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries.

TREES AND WAVES: A PRESENT-DAY ENGLISH EXAMPLE

The first example for discussion is a recent development which clearly demonstrates the close relationship of extra- to intralinguistic mechanisms in the triggering of sound-change, and which shows the emergence of a new phonological distribution. Incidentally, it also demonstrates nicely the way in which concentration on phonology at the expense of allophonic realisations can cause something significant to be missed about the way in which sound-change takes place.

The example chosen here is Scouse, a working-class variety of English spoken in Liverpool. The origins of this variety have been studied in detail by G. Knowles (1978:1):

Scouse is the dialect which developed in Liverpool in the nineteenth century, and has since spread to the surrounding dialects of Lancashire and Cheshire. Until the middle of the last century, Liverpool drew its population from the counties of the North-West of England; but after the potato famine of the 1840s, hundreds of thousands of Irishmen passed through its port, and many of them settled there. At the time of the 1861 census, 25 per cent of the city population were Irish immigrants. The resulting dialect is an interesting hybrid: on the phonological level it remains similar to the dialects of neighbouring Northern towns, but phonetically it has been heavily influenced by Anglo-Irish.

In Present-Day English, the blend of North-West English and Anglo-Irish culture manifests itself in Scouse pronunciation. On the one hand, Scouse shares important structural features with Northern England, notably in vocalism. Distinctions of the *foot/strut* and *trap/bath* type, characteristic of the Southern half of England, have not occurred in Scouse; thus *mud: good* (both with [ʊ]), *pass: gas* (both with [a]) are good rhymes in this variety (see Wells 1982:371; cf. RP [fʊt, strʌt, træp, bɑθ]). The distinctions do, however, appear in Irish English (Wells 1982: 419), even if the phonetic realisations are rather different from Southern English usage.

The phonetic realisations of a number of phonemes demonstrate the clear impact of Southern Irish English on Scouse, however. Thus, for /θ, ð/, [t, ð] appear; Knowles (1974:323) found forms such as [tʰi] *three*, [tʰu:] *truth*, [mʰnt] *month*, [tʰat] *that* in the speech of many working-class Catholic Liverpudlians. Such forms are generally characteristic of Southern Irish English. In terms of phonemic structure, however, there is for the most part no difference between Scouse and more widespread Northern English usage, for minimal pairs such as *tin: thin* in both varieties attest to the existence of distinct phonemes. The difference is a phonetic one, and it seems to correlate with social class. In calling for a theory of 'sociolinguistic

phonetics', Knowles has noted the importance of quite delicate phonetic distinctions in marking sociolinguistic differentiation.

There are indications, though, that contact with Irish English is beginning to affect the *phonological* structure of Scouse—in other words, allophonic variation is leading to a phonological development in the way described in general terms at the outset of this chapter. In some varieties of Scouse, [dat] *that* appears as a variable beside [ʔat]. The use of [dat] as opposed to [ʔat] is specifically a feature of urban varieties of Southern Irish English, for instance those used in Dublin. It may be presumed that this development is not unconnected with interaction with British English varieties, commonplace in the Irish capital. The English stereotype of Irish pronunciation, reflected in spellings such as *think, thirty* for 'think, thirty', includes the use of /t, d/ for /θ, ð/. The reason is that [t, d] in British English accents are typically realisations of /t, d/ in particular conditioning environments, such as neighbouring /θ, ð/, for example *eightth, not that*, whereas in Irish English [t, d] are realisations of a distinct phoneme, /θ, ð/. In an urban environment of weak social ties, where Irish and British English accents will be monitored together, the adoption of the English stereotype by Dubliners marking their distinctive Irishness is to be expected.

The question of the appropriate phonemic symbol for the Irish dental phonemes corresponding to the English fricatives is worth some brief discussion. J.C. Wells puts the issue fairly as follows, and in so doing indicates that British and Irish English—just as Southern English and Scots—are part of the same linguistic continuum and thus liable to interact with each other:

We could of course choose to symbolize the Irish English dental phonemes as /t/ and /d/ rather than as the phonetically inaccurate /θ/ and /ð/. But this would raise other difficulties, particularly when making a phonemic transcription of the many middle-class southern Irish who fluctuate between plosive and fricative realizations.

(Wells 1982:429)

The present-day Liverpoolian variety of English, it would seem, is a good example of at least three things relevant to the argument of this book. First, it shows how the variational characteristics of an individual variety relate closely to historical development. Second, it is a good example of the way in which, in the twentieth century, urban developments have become linguistic focal points for the surrounding countryside. Finally, it demonstrates the way in which a given variety emerges from a mixture of *inheritance* (i.e. from Northern ancestors) and *contact* (i.e. through interaction with Irish English).

A DESCRIPTION OF THE GREAT VOWEL SHIFT

It has just been argued that the triggering of a particular linguistic change was the result of the interplay between very small distinctions between varieties. In the remainder of this chapter, it will be suggested that the existence of such fine distinctions, with subsequent interaction between varieties, lies behind at least some of the most important large-scale sound-changes in the history of English, notably the Great Vowel Shift of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries. This sound change, which was first christened 'Great' by O.Jespersen, was recently described as 'a revolution in the pronunciation of long vowels whose causes remain mysterious' (Pinker 1994:250). The aim here is to present an account of the origins and development of the Shift which correlates with the model of change being developed in this book.

It seems appropriate first of all, however, to give some account of the process of implementation of the change once triggered, since it is from the analysis of the patterns of implementation that the hypothesis as to the triggering of the Shift is derived. Figure 5.1 is a traditional diagrammatic representation of the

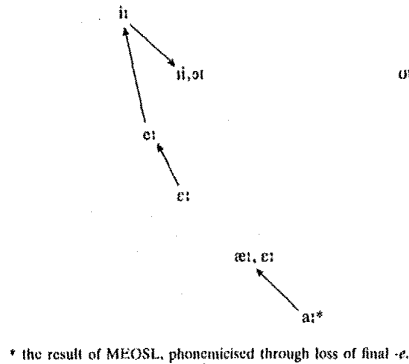


Figure 5.1 The Great Vowel Shift (traditional model, after Görlach 1991:67)

process of the Shift (after Görlach 1991:67). In brief: in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, the lexical distribution of the long-vowel phonemes of Late Middle English changed radically in an apparently ordered way. These vowels were raised or, if in close position already, diphthongised; examples in Southern English are /li:ʔ/ > /lɛʔ/ *life*, /hu:s/ > /hɛʊs/ *house*, /de:d/ > /dɛ:d/ *deed*, /go:d/ > /gu:d/ *good*, /dɛ:ʔ/ > /de:ʔ/ *deal*, /bɔ:t/ > /bo:t/ *boat*, /na:mə/ > /nɛ:m/ *name*. The latter transcriptions given here, of course, represent the immediate outcome of the Shift-process; subsequent raisings, shortenings and diphthongisations during and since the Early Modern English period have modified these outputs.

Traditionally it has been argued that the triggering of the Shift demanded as a precondition two processes acting in combination: a tendency of the close vowels to produce diphthongal allophones, and a tendency of the mid- and open vowels to produce raised allophones. Both processes, whereby the *potential* for the triggering of change is set up, are entirely conceivable phonetically as the result of the selection of forceful- and relaxed-style variants within the variational space available for each phoneme; both phenomena have been observed in modern varieties of English. In stage I, the phonemes /i:/ and /u:/ developed within their respective variational spaces a series of slurred relaxed realisations with preceding on-glides: [ɪ], [ə] and [ʊ u], [əʊ]. In stage II, the mid-close vowels /e:/, /o:/ were raised, in forceful-style conditions, to /i:/, /u:/ respectively, and the [ɪ], [ʊ] type allophones were phonemicised; in turn, Middle English /ɛ:/, /ɔ:/ were raised to /e:/, /o:/, and Middle English /a:/ was raised to /ɛ:/ (Wells 1982:184–186).

At first sight, such an account of the Shift involves a major paradox, and a number of scholars have been reluctant to accept it (e.g. Stockwell and Minkova 1988a: 357). Why does it require in some parts of the process the selection of forceful-style variants and, in others, relaxed ones? The answer must be to do with functional monitoring, for if only forceful-style variants were always selected there would be a concentration of vowels in the close and mid-close area, reducing the potential for meaningful distinctions (Samuels 1972:41–3).

Another characteristic of the Shift is that it appears to have operated *more thoroughly in some parts of the* English-speaking area than in others. In the North of England and in Scotland, for instance, the Shift seems to have operated on the front-vowel system inherited from Late Middle English, but to have largely failed in

the back series; cf. the Present-Day Scots forms *coo*, *hoo*, *noo* [kuː, huː, nuː] 'cow', 'how', 'now', from Old English *cā*, *hū*, *nū*). The retention of undiphthongised close back vowels from the Middle English period is not restricted to Scots but is also found in Northern England (see Kolb 1966). The Shift, then, would seem to have operated to its fullest extent in the Southern half of England.

EVIDENCE FOR THE GREAT VOWEL SHIFT

The occurrence and dating of the Shift can be proved by an examination of the fate of loanwords into English. For instance, the stressed vowels in words such as *tureen*, *soup* in Present-Day English have not been subjected to diphthongisation because they were borrowed into English after the Shift ceased to operate, whereas words like *round*, *guile*, which entered English before c. 1400, have been so subjected, (cf. French *terrine*, *soupe*, *rond*/'round-', *guile*).

The development may be further illustrated by an early source of evidence: the late-fifteenth-century anonymous Welsh *Hymn to the Virgin*. The *Hymn to the Virgin* was composed, a little before 1500, as an attempt to apply Welsh orthography and metrical practice to an English text. The circumstances of its composition are peculiar; according to one version of its prologue, it was written because

It happened once in Oxford that the Englishmen were scoffing at the Welsh and dispraising them greatly because of their lack of scholarship. ...[A Welshman responded by composing] this English ode in *Cynghanedd groes*, which an Englishman cannot compose.

(trans. Dobson 1955:112)

The importance of the Welsh *Hymn* is that it is the best early evidence for the diphthongisation of Middle English /iː, uː/ and the raising of Middle English /eː, oː/ to be had. Since the phonetic significance of the Welsh spelling used in the Welsh *Hymn* is known, it is possible to interpret forms such as the following as representing diphthongal or raised sounds, such as ⟨swn⟩ (with Welsh ⟨w⟩/u(ː)/) 'soon' (Old English *sōna*); ⟨kreist⟩ (with Welsh ⟨ei⟩/eɪ/) 'Christ' (Old English *Crīst*); ⟨kwīn⟩ (with Welsh ⟨i⟩/i(ː)/) 'queen' (Old English *cwēn*); ⟨wythowt⟩ (with Welsh ⟨ow⟩/əu/) 'without' (Old English *wiþūtan*).¹

Other fifteenth-century evidence, such as sporadic rhyming practice in contemporary verse, or occasional spellings in private letters of the period, such as those of the Pastons and the Celys, is usually hard to interpret. However, for what it is worth, the evidence of the Welsh *Hymn* is supported by sporadic spellings in other fifteenth-century texts: *credyll* 'cradle' (Bokenham's *Poems*, c. 1443), *symed* 'seemed' (in letters written for Margaret Paston) (see further Wyld 1923:21).

THE PROBLEM OF TRIGGERING

The evidence for the Shift's having taken place, therefore, is fairly clear, and the processes involved in its implementation seem to be phonetically straightforward. However, the problem of *triggering* remains: why did the change happen, why did it happen when and where it did, and why did it stop? What caused the selection of particular variables but not others in an apparently ordered sequence? In attempting to answer these questions, a number of different solutions will be put forward, for there seems at least a possibility that the circumstances (and perhaps even the date) of actuation varied diatopically. It will be demonstrated that an understanding of both extra- and intralinguistic contexts is essential if an understanding of the origins of the phenomenon is to be achieved.

EXTRALINGUISTIC CORRESPONDENCES I: THE RISE OF LONDON

In accounting for any historical event, the first objective is to assemble the correspondences between that event and others contemporary with it. The Great Vowel Shift seems to have begun in the South-East of England in the years after 1400, and there are two key extralinguistic developments which correspond with it: the development of an urban setting for the vernacular, and the appearance of class-based standardisation in speech.

It has long been known that the history of the English language correlates with geography. Even in Roman times, before the coming of the Anglo-Saxons, the province of Britannia was divided into a richer and more prosperous South and East, and a poorer and more barren North and West. This distinction derives from the geology of the countryside; most first-class land appears in an area to the south of a line running from the River Humber to the headwaters of the River Severn, whereas vast tracts of the West Country, Wales, the North of England and Scotland are characterised by much poorer land-quality than in more southerly and easterly counties. This distinction, of course, is a crude generalisation. There were, and are, obvious pockets of prosperity outside the South and East, such as Fife in Scotland, or the counties of Herefordshire and Worcestershire in the South-West Midlands; and agricultural developments, such as the clearing of fertile virgin land in Yorkshire associated with medieval monastic foundations, blur the North-West/South-East distinction. Nevertheless, such a distinction is accepted by geographers as a broadly true assessment of Britain's wealth in land. And wealth in land has been central to the nation's economic development; until the Industrial Revolution of the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, which brought about the rise of the great industrial cities of the North, Britain was an agricultural country with few urban centres.

The demographic implications of this geographical setting are plain. The population of the British Isles has always tended to be concentrated in the South and East; this area has traditionally attracted immigrants from the poorer parts of the country, and its societies may be characterised as consisting of rather weak social networks within a comparatively fluid class structure. In contrast, the North and West for much of the last two millennia has been an area of pioneering or wilderness societies, characterised by strong social ties over long distances—needed in a relatively hostile natural environment—and by long-sustained hierarchical loyalties.

It is, therefore, no coincidence that, until the Industrial Revolution of the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, the North and West of England was politically conservative, maintaining Anglo-Saxon and Norse traditions after the Norman Conquest, and supporting the Catholic Church against Henry VIII in the sixteenth century and king against parliament in the seventeenth. The South and East has been consistently more radical; it is in this area that we see the rise of a middle class towards the end of the Middle Ages and the creation, in London, of what was for many years the only English city comparable in size to European conurbations.

The rise in the size and importance of London is the most distinctive feature of late medieval society, and its rapid development seems to coincide in date with the triggering of the Great Vowel Shift. Towns in the Middle Ages provided trading opportunities, being centres for the markets and fairs which were essential for a developing economy; they also made possible the development of craft-skills. London was by far the most important of these concentrations, being the seat of government as well as the country's major trading port, and it attracted immigrants from further and further afield during the course of the period, especially as agrarian development increased the population beyond that which could be supported by the land. Modern demographic research (recorded in e.g. Burnley 1983:112–113) has reconstructed the pattern of immigration into the capital during the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries; this pattern has already been discussed in the previous chapter, in that the evolution of written language in London during the fourteenth and fifteenth

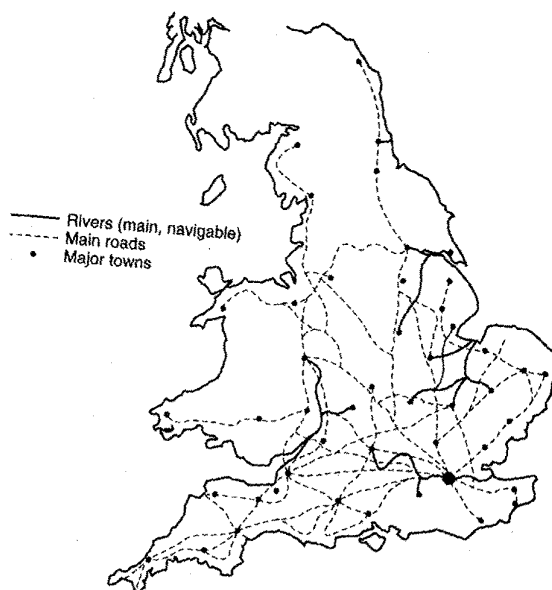


Figure 5.2 Main road and river systems, c. 1600 (after Falkus and Gillingham 1981:179)

centuries demonstrates the appearance within London usage of forms deriving from Midlands dialects. Figure 5.2 (after Falkus and Gillingham 1981:179) shows how London was at the centre of contemporary road-and water-borne communication.

William the Conqueror's *Domesday Book* of 1086 reveals that the land, the basis of medieval economic and political power, was controlled by a relatively small class of landlords, consisting of the king, his magnates and leading churchmen and ecclesiastical institutions; and this structure persisted even after the Dissolution of the Monasteries by Henry VIII in the sixteenth century. However, there were fluctuations and signs of new developments. The slump in population following the Black Death in the fourteenth century meant a labour shortage and a consequent increase in prosperity for the remaining lower-class population, which could demand higher incomes. And the development of towns like London favoured the emergence of an urban middle class—a level of society which rose to prominence in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, asserting its power most formidably in the English Civil Wars of the 1640s. It might therefore be expected, given the model of language in relation to society which has been developed in this book, that linguistic change during this period is likely to reflect dynamic social change.

EXTRALINGUISTIC CORRESPONDENCES II: STANDARDISATION

The second extralinguistic correspondence to the Shift is that it is during the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries that evidence begins to be found for the appearance of a standardised form of speech. Whereas the evidence for the standardisation of writing can be observed directly, through the analysis of surviving manuscripts and printed books, the evidence for the standardisation of speech can only be retrieved indirectly, through the analysis of contemporary commentary on the state of the spoken language, and through the procedures of linguistic reconstruction.

Before the sixteenth century, the evidence is very uncertain for standardisation of speech. Often cited in this context is the attempt by the Londoner Geoffrey Chaucer to represent Northern speech in his characterisation of two students in *The Reeve's Tale* (see Tolkien 1934; also Smith 1995 and references there cited). However, although Chaucer may mock the Northernisms of these young men, his humour seems to be based upon the oddness of people from different parts of the country rather than from a sense of a standardised spoken language; the two Northerners in the poem seem, in any case, to be of a slightly higher social class than the Cambridgeshire miller whom they fool. Social class does not seem to have been distinguished by dialect or accent in the generations preceding Chaucer; rather, English-speakers who wished to mark their social distinctiveness during the fourteenth century seem to have adopted the expedient of studding their language with French-derived vocabulary.

During the fifteenth century, however, there is some evidence for the existence of prestigious models of speech in which the socially marked forms were not restricted to vocabulary. Perhaps the earliest example showing that spoken dialect (grammar and pronunciation) is socially significant is the use of a 'Southren tothe' by the comic sheepstealer Mak in the Wakefield (Yorkshire) *Second Shepherds' Play*, which dates from the early fifteenth century. Mak's affectation of Southern dialect features of grammar, beside French-derived vocabulary, seems to correlate with the claim he makes that he is a 'yoman...of the kyng' (Cawley 1958:48).

It is true that, well into the sixteenth century, courtiers such as Sir Thomas Wyatt could retain Kenticisms in their speech without, apparently, any contemporary social stigmatisation; and, although his variety of speech attracted contemporary comment, Sir Walter Raleigh seems to have suffered no discrimination in his career on account of his Devon dialect. Even so, from the sixteenth century the early writers on English pronunciation do begin to describe how the 'best' language is to be found at 'court'.

Probably the most famous contemporary comment on the evolution of a spoken prestigious form of English is that made by George Puttenham (*The Arte of English Poesie*, 1589). According to Puttenham, the accomplished poet should adopt the usage of 'the better brought vp sort':

ye shall therefore take the vsuall speech of the Court, and that of London and the shires lying about London within lx. myles, and not much aboue.

(cited Burnley 1992:224–225)

Such descriptions have a sociolinguistic significance. If a prestigious language-variety has emerged in a situation of social ferment—as we know the period to have been marked by—then it may be presumed that there were people seeking to achieve this prescriptive norm of English even if it were not their original usage. The most obvious group to be identified with such seekers are the emerging middle classes of the period; peasantry and aristocracy can be assumed to be comparatively secure in their social position, and thus strongly tied to the society around them, whereas the middle classes are notoriously a social group on the move, characterised by weak social ties.

Such weakly tied people were distinguished by contemporary writers on language. A number of the orthoepists of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries make similar comments to those made by Puttenham, and, in doing so, they condemn those who practise 'dialectal' or 'affected' speech. Perhaps the best-known group of folk thus stigmatised are those known as the *Mopsae*, who are referred to by John Milton's teacher Alexander Gil in his *Logonomia Anglica* (1619, 1621). What Gil meant by the term is still a matter of scholarly controversy; but, if his statements are taken at face value, the *Mopsae* would seem to be persons whose social position has parallels in present-day society. The *Mopsae* were, in the current jargon, 'upwardly mobile', the kind of people characterised by sociolinguists as having weak ties to their social class and local area, and thus prone to hypercorrect or overshoot when faced by linguistic systems perceived by them as prestigious. In other words, they are people who ape their social superiors while originating from lower strata of society. The key point to note here is to do with the appearance of perceived sociolinguistic hypercorrection in their language, which suggests that a 'higher' pronunciation was recognised by this date. Although Gil is vague about who they were—their name is simply a conventional adoption from classical pastoral, indicating country origins and femininity—they would seem most plausibly to be identified with the rising urban middle classes of the period; we shall be returning to them again towards the end of this chapter. Their significance at this point in our argument is to do with their appearance at this date; Gil, in fact, is the earliest of the orthoepists to assert clearly 'that all people who are well born and well educated use a common form of speech' (Dobson 1968:142), and thus to identify a spoken form of 'Standard English'.

INTRALINGUISTIC CORRESPONDENCES I: THE LOSS OF FINAL -E

In addition to correspondences with extralinguistic developments, the Great Vowel Shift corresponds in date and place with two intralinguistic phenomena: a grammatical change known as 'the loss of final -e', and the phonemicisation of a quantitative change known as Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening. It will be argued that there is a linkage between these phenomena and the origins of the Shift, and it is therefore necessary to examine each in turn.

It is a well-known phenomenon in the history of English that inflectional endings in Old English were subject to loss, syncretism and obscuration towards the end of the first millennium AD—all signs that inflections were less important for expressing relationships between and within phrases. This development, part of an ongoing process in the Germanic languages, will be pursued further in Chapter 7; however, it is relevant for the next stage of our argument that some discussion of the phenomenon is presented at this point.

In the fifteenth century inflectional endings other than those in use in Present-Day English were finally lost, the result being that 'the most significant prosodic change in the history of the language [took place]...by which English became the most monosyllabic language in Europe' (Samuels 1972:145). This change is known as 'the loss of final -e'.

There are already indications of the disappearance of final -e in unstressed, mostly closed-class words in Late Old Northumbrian texts of the eleventh century, where forms such as *hir*, *þær*, *þonne*, *son* appear beside *hire*, *þære*, *þonne*, *sona*; and, in Northern Middle English texts, final -e in stressed words disappears from at the latest the thirteenth century onwards. The obscuration of unstressed syllables is a feature of all the Late Old English dialects, but the dialectal distribution of the loss of -e suggests strongly that it was encouraged by contact with Old Norse. Large-scale contact between Old Norse and Old Anglian has traditionally been assumed to favour inflectional weakening and, ultimately, loss.

In the South and Midlands, final *-e* remained until the early fifteenth century, especially as an adjectival inflection. This is evidenced by (for example) the metrical usage of Chaucer, where final *-e* was used in adjectives as a marker of plurality and/or definiteness, thus:

the gode man 'the good man'
gode men 'good men'
 but *god man* 'good man'

Particular pressure to retain such an *-e* would come about in poetic contexts, where rhythmical regularity would be an important requirement. (There would not be similar pressure to retain *-e* in polysyllabic adjectives, since they would not form part of a regular sequence of metrical feet.)

Final *-e*, although it performed a useful prosodic function in Chaucerian English, was eventually lost, however. The reason must be to do with language-contact; the evidence from the development of written incipient standardised language is that London English was becoming increasingly influenced by Central Midland dialects during the late fourteenth and early fifteenth centuries (see Chapter 4 above, *passim*), and these dialects, which had a distinct prosody, had ceased to use final *-e* long before. The complete loss of final *-e* in London English, therefore, may be seen as a belated and indirect effect of the Scandinavian invasions.

INTRALINGUISTIC CORRESPONDENCES II: MIDDLE ENGLISH OPEN SYLLABLE LENGTHENING

The obscuration of unstressed syllables in the history of English is relevant to the next stage of the argument, which is to do with quantitative change in the history of English.

In Old English, words could be distinguished in meaning by the quantity of the vowels they contain: thus Old English has minimal pairs of the type *god* 'God', *gōd* 'good'. However, this distinction began to be lost towards the end of the Old English period. The loss of this distinction demonstrates the interaction of two forces: articulatory change, and an isochronicity requirement which is an aspect of so-called phonological setting.

The second of these two concepts needs some explanation. It seems to be a feature of English throughout its history that there is a correlation between stress and the length of syllables. This is demonstrated by the way in which stresses occur at regular intervals in the spoken mode; such regularity lies behind the metrical norms of English poetry. Isochronicity, of course, can vary between languages. We perceive this variation, most obviously, in folk speaking a language not their own; thus Southern Europeans will often say something like 'Its-a-nice-a-day' when speaking English in order to maintain the isochronicity requirement of their own language. Such patterns are obviously maintained within speech-communities by the monitoring process outlined in Chapter 3 above; that they are extremely persistent phenomena is proved by the fact that non-native speakers of a foreign tongue, however otherwise fluent and accurate they may be, find it extraordinarily hard to overcome their native isochronicity requirements when attempting speech in another language.

Since this requirement has, amongst other things, implications for the practice of verse, it is from poetry that much of our information about quantitative distributions of Old English vowels is derived; for Old English scansion requires that stress should be placed upon long syllables—that is, a syllable whose end-rhyming element ('peak' and 'coda') consisted of either a long vowel followed by a consonant in the same syllable (e.g. *gōd* 'good'), or a short vowel followed by two consonants in the same syllable (e.g. *cild* 'child'). By a further process, known as *resolution*, stress may be placed on a cluster of two short syllables (e.g. *nama* 'name'). This last example shows that, very roughly, a short syllable was considered to be half

the length of a long syllable, and that the rhyming element of a long syllable could consist of one of the following combinations: (where V= any vowel, VV=a long vowel or diphthong, C=any consonant) VCC, VVC or VCV.

Between the Late Old and Late Middle English periods, there seems to have been a series of changes in the quantities of English vowels: lengthening and shortening before certain consonant-groups in the Late Old English Period and, after c. 1200, Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening. For the purposes of the argument presented here, the most important was the last of these processes. (For a description and explanation of the Late Old English quantitative changes not discussed here, see Campbell 1959:120–122, Hogg 1992a:210–214.)

Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening is a process whereby originally short vowels were lengthened in the stressed open syllables of disyllabic words, for instance Old English *faran* > Middle English *fāren* [faːrən] 'go'. It seems to have been the result of a kind of compensatory lengthening, whereby the isochronicity principle referred to on page 95 above was maintained across two syllables. It would appear that forms such as *faran*, *nama*, which would count as 'resolved' elements in Old English verse, lost in metrical weight, possibly because the vowels in the unstressed syllables became even less stressed; such a process would produce a 'defective' rhyming element, which might be symbolised VCv.

It may be significant that the lengthening was earliest and furthest advanced in the North, where inflectional endings were obscured first as the result of contact between English and Scandinavian. The phenomenon certainly seems to correspond in date with other likely Scandinavian-influenced innovations such as the fronting of long back vowels. Both phenomena perhaps relate to the twelfth-century break-up of tight-knit communities which seems to have accompanied the spread of Scandinavianised culture northwards and southwards from the original focal area of Viking settlement.

The process of lengthening seems to have taken place in two phases; an earlier phase in which *a*, *e*, *o* were lengthened, and a later phase in which lengthening of *i*, *u* took place. It has been argued that the lowering of *i*, *u* was delayed because closer vowels seem, phonetically, to resist lengthening (Jones 1989: 114). It is worth noting in this connection that, even in Present-Day English, vowels in the North tend to be realised phonetically as more open in quality than in the South (Wells 1982:356); this fact might account for the reluctance of *i*, *u* to undergo lengthening in the ancestor of the Present-Day Southern English reference accent, Received Pronunciation (only a few examples showing lengthening of *i*, *u* exist in Received Pronunciation, e.g. 'evil' (Old English *yfel*), 'week' (Old English *wicu*); compare Present-Day Received Pronunciation 'written' (Old English *writen*)).

In support of this last point, it may be noted that there is some sixteenth- and seventeenth-century evidence that, in London, Middle English short *e*, *o*, the vowels which were subjected (in certain circumstances) to Open Syllable Lengthening but are otherwise comparatively stable in realisation in the history of English, were realised as a pair of intermediate vowels, half-way between mid-open and mid-close. Thus F.Cercignani (1981:60) would interpret the evidence of the early phonetician Robert Robinson as implying that Middle English /*ɛ*/ could be realised at the beginning of the seventeenth century as [ɛ̞] in prestigious speech, a sound roughly comparable with its reflex in Present-Day English Received Pronunciation.

The evidence for the date of Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening is fairly firm. Important negative evidence in this regard is supplied by a poem called the *Ormulum* (MS Oxford, Bodleian Library, Junius 1). This text is a holograph cycle of metrical sermons written by a priest called Orm in Lincolnshire in the late twelfth century; the name of the poem, derived from that of its author, reflects a contemporary liking for titles such as *Speculum* etc. The literary interest of this exceedingly long work (20,000 lines survive, perhaps one-eighth of the planned collection) is slight; but its interest for the historical linguist is conversely

great. Orm devised a special phonetic spelling for his sermons to indicate (amongst other things) quantitative distinctions; his use of rhythm suggests that the work was to be intoned, and the use of a special spelling would therefore be an aid to public performance. Because of this special orthography, Orm is an invaluable witness for contemporary English pronunciation. His spelling-practice was not generally imitated, although there are one or two parallels in some late-eleventh-century additions to two earlyeleventh-century manuscripts of Ælfric's *Catholic Homilies* (MSS Oxford, Bodleian Library, Bodley 340 and 342; see Sisam 1953:186–195 for an important discussion).

Most scholars consider that Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening had not happened in the language of Orm, who regularly uses a diacritic indicating a short vowel over vowels which might be presumed to undergo lengthening, for instance *tākenn* 'take' vs. *takenn* 'token', 'and he avoids disyllabic words with original short vowels in an open syllable in the last foot of his verse, which is required to be a quantitative trochee' (Dobson 1962:132). However, Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening certainly seems to have taken place by the mid-thirteenth century, being proved by rhymes in texts from that period. For instance, *On god ureisun of ure lefdi* in MS London, British Library, Cotton Nero A.xiv has *reade* 'red' (Old English *rēad*) : *iureden* 'injure' (Old English *gewerdan* with metathesis) 36–37, *ore* 'mercy' (Old English *ār*) : *uorloren* 'lost' (Old English *forloren*) 73–74. This latter text, although surviving in a West Midland manuscript, seems to be East Midland in origin. Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening seems to have begun in the North and spread South (Jordan 1974:47–48).

It is perhaps worth noting that processes similar to Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening, with similar outputs, are recorded in Scandinavian and Low German (see Haugen 1976:258–259). A distinction between 'weakened' and 'lost' unstressed vowels has been detected here (see Haugen 1976:260); and, in the Scandinavian languages, the close and mid stressed vowels *e*, *i*, *o*, *u* seem to have developed more open realisations during the course of the thirteenth century, which realisations seem to have been a prerequisite for lengthening (Gordon 1957:267). Given the similarities between Scandinavian and Anglian which predate the Viking invasions, it is possible that Old Anglian had lower realisations of the Old English short vowels than the Saxon dialects, which vowels were thus more predisposed to undergo lengthening. Further research, of a comparative nature, might be illuminating in this context.

Since it will be argued that the operation of Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening has a significance for the actuation of the Great Vowel Shift, a special notation (after Dobson 1962) is used from time to time in what follows to represent vowels subject to the process: *i*-, *u*-, *a*-, *e*-, *o*-. This philological notation has the virtue of avoiding a commitment to a specific phonemic or allophonic interpretation while making clear which vowels are being referred to.

DIALECTAL DIFFERENCES AND INTERACTION IN THE ORIGINS OF THE SHIFT

As in the investigation of any historical event, the origins of the Great Vowel Shift are to be found in the analysis of the correspondences described above. However, a caveat remains. One of the main difficulties faced by students of the Shift is the insistence by some authorities that it is a unitary phenomenon, that is, all manifestations of vowel shifting in varieties of English and Scots during the late Middle Ages are the result of the same triggering mechanism. Of course, this may not necessarily be the case; it is quite possible for two separate sound-changes to take place in different dialects but to appear—because very similar in their effects—to be the same phenomenon. Thus, in Old English, initial palatal consonants had a similar effect on following vowels in West Saxon and in Old Northumbrian, but the absence of a similar phenomenon in the intermediate Mercian dialects suggests that the two sound-changes, although similar in

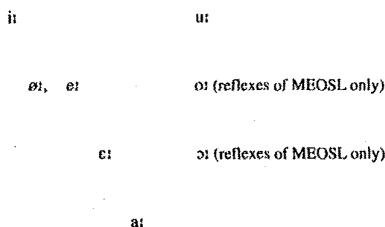


Figure 5.3 The Great Vowel Shift in the North (a): pre-Shift

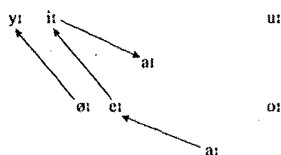


Figure 5.4 The Great Vowel Shift in the North (b): process of Shift

outcome, were triggered differently. (On the role of initial palatal consonants in sound-change in prehistoric Old English, see Campbell 1959:64–71, Hogg 1992a:106–121.)

Thus it is important in studying a major development, such as the Great Vowel Shift, to be aware that the triggers of the change may differ diatopically. Three regions of the country will be examined here, since they demonstrate the range of mechanisms that, it is suggested, was involved in the process: the North (i.e. the English- and Scots-speaking area to the north of a line running approximately between mid-Lincolnshire and the Wirral peninsula), London (with special reference to the class-dialects of the capital) and East Anglia (i.e. modern Norfolk and Suffolk).

THE NORTHERN SHIFT

(See Figures 5.3 and 5.4.) The process of the Shift in the Northern dialects has received, quite rightly, a good deal of attention from scholars (e.g. in Lass 1976). Although the processes involved in the Northern Shift are useful for our understanding of the process of triggering of the wider Shift, it is suggested here that the problem presented by these dialects is distinct from that manifested by more southerly varieties. In the North there was a superfluity of front vowels, brought about most probably through contact with Scandinavian. Thus Old English /i:, e:/ were joined in the front series by /ø:/ derived from Old English *ō*, cf. Scots *gude* 'good' beside Southern Middle English *go(o)d*; and Old English *ā*, Old Norse *ā*, which seems to have been a back vowel, was fronted to /a:/, cf. Scots *hame* 'home' beside Southern Middle English *ho(o)m*. Subsequently, the Northern area developed a three-height long-vowel system, brought about by the raising of /e:, ø:/ (see Dobson 1968:612, 625, 674–675).

It is interesting that the Shift in the North operated in the front series but seems barely to have affected the long back vowels. Thus there must have been conditions that favoured shifting in the former but not in the latter. Part of the explanation may be to do with the comparatively crowded close and mid-close front-

vowel system, which must have favoured the dissimilation of phonemes within the available variational space—a phenomenon recorded in a number of languages (see further Moulton 1962). There is a persistent tendency for rounded front vowels, such as /ø:/, to unround in the history of English, since roundness, as a distinctive feature, seems to correlate in most dialects of English with back vowels. Thus some varieties of Present-Day Northern English have developed forms such as [gʰəʊs] 'goose' (Old English *gōs*) (Wells 1982: 359), as the reflex of Middle English [gø:s]; cf. also Present-Day Scots [fʰu] 'foot' (Old English *fōt*). For that reason /ø:/, the peculiar Northern reflex of Old English *ō*, must have been liable to contribute, if sporadically, to this pressure.

The development of /a:/ in the North remains a little puzzling; in this region, *a-* had become identified with older /a:/ (derived from the fronting of Old English *ā*, Old Norse *ǣ*), which seems to have undergone a raising to /ɛ:/ (or even /e:/) earlier than in the South, especially in the environment of a following [s] (see Dobson 1968:612, 625; Jordan 1974:238). It is just possible that this change may have something to do with the Northern development whereby /ai/ merged with older /a:/; in certain parts of the North-West Midlands, Middle English /ai/ is realised as /ɛ:/ and, in contact situations, it is possible that older /a:/ may have become associated with this development (see further Jordan 1974:118, 135–136, 238). Whatever its origin—and further work is needed on this topic—the raising of /a:/ must have contributed to the pressures on the close front vowels which, it is suggested here, triggered the Northern Shift.

In the back vowels, the pressures for the Shift in the Northern dialects would have been much less strong, since original Old English *ō* had been fronted earlier and the system would have been considerably less crowded. This would account for the retention of Old English /u:/ in the North long after its phonemic diphthongisation in other dialects (Figure 5.3). It is even possible that /o:/ < Middle English /ɔ:/ in the North is unconnected with the Shift. A Middle English [ɔ:] would have appeared in the North probably only as the result of Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening, and there is some evidence that Northern dialects underwent early raising of this [ɔ:] to [o:], predating the Shift (see Dobson 1968:674–675). It can be argued plausibly, therefore, that the pre-Shift back vowels still remain, with slight modifications (notably, in some environments, quantitative), in Present-Day Northern English and Scots.

This Northern Shift may have been comparatively early—perhaps not very long after the merger of Middle English /ai/ with Middle English /a:/ in the late fourteenth century (see Jordan 1974:135–136). There is some slight evidence that the diphthongisation of Middle English /i:/ proceeded more quickly in the North than elsewhere (see Jordan 1974:237 and references there cited). However, the Northern Shift cannot have been the source for the similar process in the South, for at least two reasons: first, it took place in a part of the country comparatively isolated from the rest; and, second, it failed in the back series of Middle English long vowels, which were fully affected by the Shift in the South.

THE SOUTHERN AND MIDLANDS SHIFTS

The Shift was much more extensive in its effects in Southern and Midland Middle English; and here it is argued that the extralinguistic and intralinguistic correspondences indicated on pages 89–98 above are crucial in accounting for the development.

The key process here is phonemicisation, as described on pages 80–81 above. In some dialect regions, new phonemes emerged in English as a result of Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening. These new phonemes, in many Southern and Midland areas, do not seem to have emerged until the loss of final *-e*. Until that time, *a-*, *e-*, *o-* would simply have been perceived as lengthened allophones of /a, ɛ, ɔ/ (=Old English *ā/æ, e, o*), and court-poets like Chaucer and Gower, who represent the rhyming practice of an

System I		System II	
iɪ	> ii	ui	> uu
oi	> ci*	oi	> oi*
ei*		ei	> ei
ei		ai*	> ei, ei
ai*	> ai		

Figure 5.5 Competing systems in early-fifteenth-century London (* MEOSL phonemes)
exalted social circle, distinguish between /eɪ/, /oɪ/, /ɛɪ/, /ɪə/ and e-, o- in their rhymes (see Dobson 1962: 134–135 and references there cited).

This habit contrasts with the practice of merging *e*, *o*- with /ɛ:/, /ɔ:/ adopted in other Midland and Southern dialects, such as that represented by *On god ureisun of are lefdi*, referred to on page 98 above. Since it seems to be the case, supported by Present-Day English and orthoepical evidence, that Chaucer's short /ɛ, ɔ/ vowels had a slightly closer quality than those used further North, lengthened /ɛ, ɔ/ [ɛ̄, ɔ̄] would have been realised as [ɛ̄¹, ɔ̄¹] in the dialects descended from the poet's. The best-known evidence for such a distinction in Chaucer's own language is offered by the stanza from *Troilus and Criseyde* (Book V, lines 22ff.), in which *loore* 'teaching' and *more* 'more' have /ɔ:/ (from Old English *a*), and *forlore* 'lost entirely', *more* 'root' (Old English *moru*), *tofore* 'before' have *o*:-

This Troilus, withouten reed or loore,
As man that hath his joies ek forloore,
Was waytyng on his lady evere more
As she that was the sothfast crop and more
Of al his lust or joies heretofore.
But Troilus, now far-wel at thi joie,
For shallow nevere sen hire eft in Troie!

(Benson 1988:560)

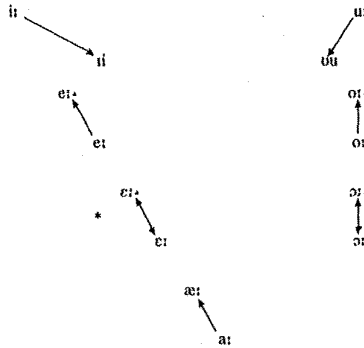
With the loss of final *-e*, however, *a-*, *e-*, *o-*, became phonemic in the dialect which descended from Chaucer's. There would thus have resulted two competing phonological systems in the London area:

System I /e:/, e- (now phonemic, presumably /e:/, /e:/—used by those people who may be roughly characterised as descendants of Chaucer (i.e. those from the high social circles which Chaucer represented); this variety, in which e- was a closer vowel than /e:/, may reasonably be supposed to have held prestige;

System II /e:/, /ɛ:/, in which *e-* had merged with /ɛ:/—used by many Southern and Midland speakers other than those just characterised as descendants of Chaucer.

Parallel systems would have existed for the back vowels, that is, I:/o:/, o-, /ɔ:/; II:/o:/, /ɔ:/ (see Figure 5.5).

(For the next stage in the argument, reference should be made throughout to Figures 5.5 and 5.6.) When these two systems came into contact, as they would in early-fifteenth-century London, it would be apparent to System-II speakers that (prestigious) System-I speakers used /*ɛ*¹/ in many words where System II had /*ɛ*²/; System-II speakers would have no means of determining which words should have /*ɛ*¹/ and which /*ɛ*²/, since the grammatical marker, final -e, had been lost. Thus it would be entirely natural for those System-II



* subsequent merger of ME /eɪ, oɪ/ with ME e, o- on /eɪ, oɪ/, through sociolinguistic distancing.

Figure 5.6 The Great Vowel Shift: Chaucer's descendants

speakers attempting to imitate System I to use [eɪ˦]—or, more probably, the next closer phoneme in their system, viz. /eɪ/—in words in which System-I speakers would have /eɪ/, as well as in those in which System-I speakers had /eɪ˦/. A similar situation may be held to have occurred with regard to the back vowels. Such raisings may be considered to represent the beginning of the Shift.

The next problem is to do with the raising of /eɪ, oɪ/. Here there is good evidence that System-I speakers would have used raised variants of /eɪ, oɪ/, viz. [eɪ˦, oɪ˦]. That Middle English /eɪ, oɪ/ were realised in Early Modern English as 'rather lax' /i, u/, that is [i˦, u˦] or even [eɪ˦, oɪ˦], is proved by adoptions from, for example, Dutch (Dobson 1968:617–618); a predisposing factor in this context might have been the especially tense [eɪ˦] favoured in contemporary French, which was sporadically realised as *i* in a few fourteenth-century English texts (Dobson 1968:656). It may be that such uses were encouraged by the continuing habit of signalling social prestige by means of French-derived vocabulary.

System-I speakers, whose social milieu demanded at least an acquaintance with French-derived vocabulary if not grammar, ought to have been capable of realising such pronunciations; and R.B. Le Page has suggested (in Samuels 1972:145–146) that there would be good reasons for the aristocracy of the late fourteenth and fifteenth centuries 'to adopt affected forms of speech as a means of "role-distancing" from the lower classes, from whom they had hitherto been differentiated by speaking French'. Such raised variants would have been 'marked', that is, stylistically salient, and thus especially liable to occur in forceful-style contexts. Furthermore, they would have been favoured, through functional monitoring, by the raising of Middle English /eɪ, oɪ/ referred to above.

System-II speakers, whose social standing did not involve as intimate a contact with French, would have perceived this raised sound /eɪ˦, oɪ˦/ as /i, u/, the next closer phoneme in their system. Such a choice would have been favoured by the tendency in their system to produce /eɪ, oɪ/ for Middle English /eɪ, oɪ/, which would have exerted upward pressure.

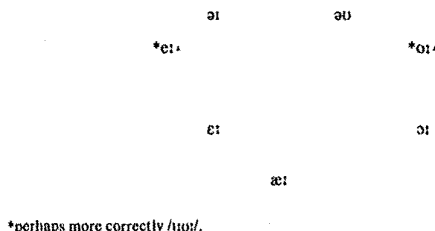


Figure 5.7 John Hart's system (1569)

Finally, the diphthongal variants of Middle English /iɪ, uɪ/, which existed all the time in relaxed-style contexts, would have been favoured through functional monitoring and selected as 'core' realisations of their phonemes. If the argument above is accepted, it seems likely that this diphthongisation was less advanced amongst System-I speakers than amongst those who used System II, given that Middle English /eɪ, oɪ/ were realised as [eɪ, oɪ] in I but [iɪ, uɪ] in II.

HART'S ORTHOGRAPHIE

The main difficulty in seeing the raising of /ɛɪ, ɔɪ/ as the actuating factor for the Shift is that the evidence of the orthoepists, notably that of John Hart, has been held by most scholars to suggest that Middle English /ɛɪ, ɔɪ/ did not undergo raising until the end of the sixteenth century, whereas /eɪ, oɪ/ had been raised, and /iɪ, uɪ/ diphthongised, well before that date.

John Hart (d. 1574) was perhaps the most important English phonetician of the sixteenth century. He was the author of three works on spelling and pronunciation: *The opening of the unreasonable writing of our inglish toung* (1551), dedicated to Edward VI and surviving only in manuscript (MS London, British Library, Royal 17.C.vii); *An Orthographie*, a major work printed in 1569; and *A Methode or comfortable beginning for all vnlearned*, a small primer printed in 1570. Rather little is known of Hart's life, other than that he was from an early age a member of the College of Heralds, becoming Chester Herald in 1566—an important court position, requiring him to act as a royal messenger as well as to be involved in the intricacies of ceremonial. From his writings on phonetic matters he seems, as might be expected, familiar with the court, and some of his recorded behaviour suggests that he thought himself the social equal of the noble military leaders with whom he had to deal. Despite ancestral roots in Devon, he writes as a Londoner (see Dobson 1968:62–66).

John Hart's system (see Figure 5.7), as revealed in his *Orthographie*, may be taken to represent the speech of a socially sophisticated Londoner, well acquainted with the 'best' (i.e. most socially approved) contemporary speech through his contact with the court. We should therefore expect Hart to be fully conversant with the speech of the descendants of those who used System I. Yet he does not seem to exhibit a raising of Middle English /ɛɪ/, and this is apparently demonstrated by his identification of Middle English /ɛɪ/ with German *ä* and French *e* (see Dobson 1968: 620–621). It is therefore necessary to pursue the problem a little further.

The solution to this difficulty suggested here depends on sociolinguistic distancing. In conditions of interaction with System-II speakers, who would have been regarded as social climbers, it can reasonably be

argued that System-I users would have tended to react against the use of /ɛ:/. There would be a tendency amongst the latter for a reactive hyperadaptation, in which /ɛ: / would be selected for the older raised phoneme /ɛ: / derived through Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening and the loss of final -e. Since the grammatical marker had disappeared, System-I speakers—or, perhaps more correctly, the descendants of System-I speakers—would have no obvious means of distinguishing the correct use of the two vowels. Ultimately, of course, this usage disappeared, to be replaced by reflexes of System II—which, incidentally, is the usual system to be found in sixteenth-century rhyming and punning contexts (see Samuels 1972:147, Dobson 1968:400–401).

THE ESSEX CONNECTION

There remains the question of the raising of Middle English [a:]. Leith (1983:148–149) holds that the Shift began with a raising of Middle English [a:], but this view cannot be accepted since the Shift in the South affected both front and back vowels; it seems clear that Middle English [a:] was a front vowel, and it cannot therefore have exerted pressure on the back series. The evidence, moreover, indicates that Middle English [a:] was not raised at the beginning of the Shift, although the circumstances of its raising, in the South at least, may have been sociolinguistically determined in a manner similar to that involved in the raising of Middle English /ɛ:/, ɛ: /.

One possibility is that the determining factor in the South may have been to do with Essex dialect. In late-fourteenth-century London, poets such as Chaucer would have had a sound [a:] in native words only as a realisation of Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening *a-*, which would not yet be a separate phoneme because final -e remained; [a:] would therefore have been an allophone of /a/ (see Dobson 1962:144–145; see also Cercignani 1981:101). In Essex, however, whose dialect seems to have correlated with the 'old London' variety which ultimately gave rise to Cockney, *a-* would have become identified with /a:/, the special Essex reflex of Old English *æ* (see Jordan 1974:81–83). When final -e was lost, it would have appeared to contemporaries that an Essex usage (viz. phonemic /a:/) had become more widespread; and an attempt would be made, by those seeking to distance themselves from the 'old Londoners', to use closer realisations available in forceful-style contexts, viz. [æ:], for which the phonological space now existed given the raising of /ɛ:/ to /ɛ:/. Such realisations seem to have survived in fashionable use up to c. 1650 (see Dobson 1968:594), only then being replaced in this register by [ɛ:] type forms when System-II usage became prestigious.

THE MOPSÆ AND THE EASTERNERS

The discussion above throws light on two groups of people who have been felt by many scholars to have been important in the development of the Shift. Following the practice of Alexander Gil, these folk are usually called (a) the 'Mopsæ' and (b) the 'Easterners'. As Dobson indicates, it is important not to confuse the two groups (1968:147), even though their behaviour is in some ways similar.

Gil's 'Easterners' seem to be the inhabitants of East Anglia, and their evidence is of great importance for the later development of mid-vowels in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries (see Samuels 1972:146–153). However, their evidence is also important for the triggering of the Shift, for it would appear that many of the processes discussed above had taken place in East Anglia much earlier than in London, and this would seem at first sight to make less plausible the description of the actuation of the Shift offered above. The solution to the problem of the Eastern dialects presented here depends upon the interaction between varieties of contemporary English, one of which held greater prestige.

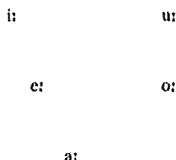


Figure 5.8 The Great Vowel Shift in East Anglia: pre-Shift

The key to the East Anglian problem is that there seems to have been a three-height system in pre-Shift East Anglia: /i:/, u:/, e:/, o:/, a:/ (see Figure 5.8). One reason for the emergence of this system was inheritance from the Old English period of Anglian $\bar{e}$ for Saxon $\bar{a}$; another reason was to do with phonetic conditioning, notably raising in the environment of a following /d, t, n, s, l, r/ (see further Dobson 1968: 612).

Given the increase in trade and other contact between the East Midlands and London in the early and mid-fifteenth century, which was itself the result of the centripetal forces associated with urbanisation discussed earlier in this chapter, this provincial East Anglian system would have come into regular contact with the prestigious London System I, in which Middle English /a:/ was realised as [æ:], Middle English /e:/ as [e:], Middle English /e:/ as [e:] (the 'French /e:/') and Middle English /i:/ was realised by diphthongal variants. In such circumstances, it is not surprising that hyperadapting tendencies took over. For East Anglians with their three-height system would tend to perceive System-I [æ:] as /e:/; System-I 'French' [e:] would be perceived as /i:/. A similar situation would hold with regard to the back series of vowels. Since 'Middle English /e:/-words' and 'Middle English /e:/-words' had merged in this dialect before the Shift, both would have been involved in the raising to /i:/. This East Anglian system is the ancestor of that which became dominant in prestigious speech from the eighteenth century (see Samuels 1972:147); it is already indicated by sporadic rhymes and spellings in the sixteenth century, for example *prych* in the *London Diary* (1550–1553) of the merchant Henry Machyn, and in rhymes such as *reach: beseech* which appear in the works of Henry Howard, Earl of Surrey, and Sir Thomas Wyatt.

The Mopsae, it is suggested here, are the descendants of those who used System II. By the early seventeenth century, the Mopsae would have had a system in which Middle English /i:/, u:/ had diphthongised, Middle English /e:/ o:/ had raised to /i:/, u:/, and Middle English /e:/, o:/ had become /e:/, o:/. Moreover, it seems probable that System-II users had /a:/ rather than System-I /æ:/; if the Mopsae had no /æ:/, they would tend when attempting System-I usage to realise /æ:/ as their next closer phoneme, /e:/—although their realisations of /e:/ must have been fairly wide-ranging, given the phonological space available. This explanation would account for the most notorious habit of the Mopsae, the use of '*kēpn*, and almost *kīpn* for 'capon' (see Dobson 1968:145, 148). Gil plainly regarded as affected such raised pronunciations of a word which, for him, had /æ:/, but, given his own phonetic script which reflected, in its essentials, the pronunciation used by Hart, he had no symbol for the Mopsae's /e:/. The speech of the Mopsae is that of the upwardly mobile, and it is therefore no coincidence that the pronunciations favoured by them became more widespread after the Civil Wars of the mid-seventeenth century and the rise to political power of a vigorously self-confident bourgeoisie.

The question remains as to why such pronunciations as those descended from System I should have taken on prestige at the end of the fourteenth and beginning of the fifteenth century. Part of the answer, as suggested by R.B.Le Page (in Samuels 1972:145–146), may be to do with 'role-distancing' amongst the

aristocracy. But, following Milroy (1992), it is argued here that the more likely innovators were the rising middle classes of the late fourteenth and early fifteenth centuries, immigrants into London like Dick Whittington, with comparatively weak ties to social class and local area. During the course of the late fourteenth and early fifteenth centuries, such immigrants originated from the East and Central Midlands—an area where System II was usual. These folk were the ancestors of Gil's Mopsae.

Such a solution to the problem of the origins of the Shift accounts for the comparative suddenness with which it took place; it also accounts for why the Shift's action ceased, since the trigger in the South and Midlands, the loss of final *-e*, could not recur. The output of Middle English Open Syllable Lengthening, the loss of final *-e*, and dialect contact in a setting of social change interacted to produce the development described at the outset of this chapter.⁵

SUBSEQUENT DEVELOPMENTS I: SEVENTEENTH CENTURY

It has been argued above that the origins of the Shift in London are to be found in the interaction of socially significant varieties. In the early seventeenth century, two varieties were in competition: the old System I, representing the speech of the descendants of Chaucer, and a rising System II, representing the pronunciations favoured by the Mopsae and their descendants. By c. 1650, these two systems had developed in the front series as follows:

I Middle English	/e:/ > /i:/, e.g. <i>meed</i> /ɛ:/ > /e:/, e.g. <i>mead</i> /a:/, /ai/ > /ɛ:/, e.g. <i>made, maid</i>
II Middle English	/e:/ > /i:/, e.g. <i>meed</i> /ɛ:/, /a:/, /ai/ > /e:/, e.g. <i>mead, made, maid</i>

The evidence for System I consists of that provided by the majority of writers on pronunciation during the period. Thus Middle English /e:/ is identified with Italian *i*; Middle English /ɛ:/ is generally reflected as /e:/ by the orthoepists; and Middle English /a:/ (with which Middle English /ai/ had become identified) passed through a stage /æ:/ to /ɛ:/ by about 1650.

Possibly the best evidence for System I, and certainly the evidence of the best contemporary phonetician, is provided by the Hertfordshire schoolmaster Christopher Cooper (*Grammar*, 1685 (Latin), 1687 (English)). Cooper's aim in his handbook was practical: he wished to instruct foreigners and English schoolchildren in correct grammar, pronunciation and, above all, spelling. Although his information is occasionally inexact as the result of what has been called 'the typical seventeenth-century attempt at an unreal symmetry' (Dobson 1968:291), he clearly has Middle English /e:/ reflected in /i:/, Middle English /ɛ:/ in /e:/, and Middle English /a:/ in /ɛ:/ (Dobson 1968:286–291).

At the time when Cooper was writing, however, there is good evidence that his mode of pronunciation was already archaic. The system which rivalled it was System II, that of the Mopsae and their descendants, and it is demonstrated most clearly in contemporary rhyming and punning practice. The earliest such rhymes in verse appear in Spenser, writing at the end of the sixteenth century, for example *seates: states*; but Dobson describes this usage as based 'either on advanced London speech or on Northern pronunciation' (1968:626). Such rhymes become much more common in the seventeenth century, as the Mopsae and their descendants became more socially significant, for the social developments of the seventeenth century—the Civil Wars, most notably—plainly had their impact in allowing an originally lower-class usage into a more prestigious environment.

Thus the following rhymes appear in the verse of seventeenth-century court poets: *speak: make* (Waller), *dream: shame: theme* (Dryden) etc. These rhymes demonstrate an identity of Middle English /e:/, /a:/ and /ai/, all of which have merged on /e:/, and show that such usage was current in the fairly prestigious milieu represented by these men. Edmund Waller (1606–1687) was educated at Eton and King's College Cambridge, was a Member of Parliament under both Charles I and Charles II, and was a member of the Royal Society from 1661; he fought on the Royalist side during the Civil Wars, being involved in a plot to seize London for the king in 1643. John Dryden (1631–1700) was a member of the lesser landed gentry, and his first major poem was the *Heroique Stanza's* on the death of Oliver Cromwell (1659); but he was to become Poet Laureate to the Stuarts and a prominent member of the intellectual establishment of his time.

System II is also found in the 'homophone lists' which start to appear from the middle of the seventeenth century. The most influential of these lists—in the sense that it was the most imitated and plundered—was that of Richard Hodges, who produced such lists in his *Special Help* (1643) and *Plainest Directions* (1649) and whose work continued to be plagiarised throughout the remainder of the seventeenth century. These lists show that rhymes such as the following were accepted in the society for which the lists were composed: *lead: layd, meads: maids, please: Plays, plead: Played, see: say* etc. (see Dobson 1968:400). Such pronunciations obviously reflect those adopted by the Mopsae and their descendants.

SUBSEQUENT DEVELOPMENTS II: EIGHTEENTH CENTURY

Just as two systems are recorded in the seventeenth century—the 'proper' pronunciation in the writings of the orthoepists and phoneticians, and a 'vulgar' one in the homophone lists—so in the eighteenth century another dual system appears. One of these was the old System II. That System II survived in prestigious use into the eighteenth century is suggested by the rhymes of writers such as Swift (1667–1745) (e.g. *speak: awake*) and Pope (1688–1744) (e.g. *speak: take*), and even Cowper (1731–1800) (e.g. *survey: sea*)—although in these cases allowance must be made for the existence of conventional eye- (as opposed to ear-) rhyme. The other was the system which is the direct ancestor of Present-Day English Received Pronunciation: System III, in which Middle English /e:/, /e:/ appear with /i:/ (cf. Present-Day English *meed: mead*), and Middle English /a:/, /a/ are reflected in /e:/ (cf. Present-Day English *made: maid*).

Although System III has just been termed 'new', it seems to have existed for some time in non-prestigious varieties, and has already been referred to. Its origins lie in East Anglia; it seems to be the result of continuing interaction of prestigious and non-prestigious varieties, whereby a non-London, especially East Anglian, three-height system came into contact with System I.

Part of the reason for the success of System III is, it would appear, functional in an intralinguistic sense: System III allowed fewer homophonic clashes than System II. However, this cannot be the whole story, for System II remains in a number of provincial, rural and traditional dialects (cf. e.g. 'stage-Irish', where *tea* is pronounced 'tay'; see Wells 1982:194ff.).

This restriction suggests that System III's success in London is not solely due to intralinguistic functional reasons but also to extralinguistic social factors peculiar to the capital. System II and System III could only come into contact in a major urban centre, such as London; in more rural areas, the opportunity for the two systems to compete would have been much rarer and thus it would have been (and is) possible for the older System II to have been retained longer. The coexistence of System II and System III in one place, London, meant that it was possible for Londoners to choose between them.

CONCLUSIONS

If the argument presented here is accepted, its implications are major. First, it suggests that, at the beginning of the fifteenth century, notions of prestige have become associated, in London at least, with the spoken as well as the written modes of language, something which, hitherto, has always been treated by scholars with justifiable suspicion.

Second, it raises the question as to whether scholars should continue to refer to the Great Vowel Shift as a unitary phenomenon at all, a matter which has excited some controversy in recent years (see Lass 1988, Stockwell and Minkova 1988a and 1988b). Its actuation and implementation seem to differ in different parts of the country, and the processes involved are not to do with some massive, sudden 'sound-shift'—which excited no contemporary comment whatsoever—but rather with a series of minor individual choices which have interacted diachronically, diatopically and sociolinguistically, resulting in a set of phonological realignments. The view offered here is that the term 'Great Vowel Shift' remains a useful label for the phenomenon, but only in the same way as 'Industrial Revolution' is a helpful shorthand method of referring to how a series of minor technological advances ultimately brought about a major cultural change (see Lass 1988:396).

Above all, it reminds us that the explanation of the triggering of a given linguistic change depends on an understanding of many interacting extra- and intralinguistic processes. A single explanation for the triggering of change is not enough; as in the physical or biological sciences, the multifactorial causation of events needs to be an accepted part of the methodology of historical linguistics.

